

My father is my unsung hero

By Jim D. Pham

*"I have the strength for everything through him who empowers me."
(Philippians 4:13)*

My father was a Vietnam War veteran. His fortitude and courage still amaze me. I am proud to be the son of this courageous veteran.

The war destroyed many lives and families. Many South Vietnamese people fled the country in fear of prosecution by the Communist army. In 1954, many people like my father migrated from North Vietnam to South Vietnam. My father, like his forefathers, had endured a generation of constant war.

"The war destroyed many lives and families."

In the chaos of that painful day in 1975, my father made a decision to remain with his army unit to defend the city of Long An, South Vietnam. By the time the Communist army arrived in Long An, most South Vietnamese soldiers had blended with the civilian population and others had already fled the country. My father remained with his army unit and defended Long An until they were captured.

My father was sent to Communist reeducation camp for 13 years, from Lào Cai, Yên Bái, North Vietnam to Chí Hòa, South Vietnam. He left behind a young wife and five children. Our family struggled for a daily meal and moved from place to place. My mother endured struggles to raise us. We all missed my father.

My mother visited my father in the reeducation camp and he advised her to find a way to take us to another country. We eventually escaped Vietnam by boat to Thailand and settled in the United States.

After 10 years in the reeducation camp, my father was released and returned home, but without his family. He was determined to be reunited and, despite the dangers, he crossed the Cambodia border. He was captured and imprisoned for three more years at Chí Hòa, South Vietnam.

He was again released and still determined to be reunited with his family. He ventured into the Cambodia border, wandering through dense jungles and rugged mountains. After two months, he managed to purchase a small boat and rowed to Thailand, where he was sent to a refugee camp.

In 1990, my father was reunited with my family in the United States. Eventually, he found work as a handyman, doing home repair, until my mother had a stroke which paralyzed her and was confined to a wheelchair. My father stayed home to aid her. Then he had a massive stroke and passed away.

I once asked my father how he dealt with the painful events in his life. He said through fortitude, endurance, hardiness and ingenuity. Most of all, love and sacrifice were his encouragement. He was willing to die for our sake. It is love that takes us everywhere we want to go. Love never fails.

My father's lifetime of service to his home country and love for his family shows that duty comes with responsibility. Now, I am a father and I want to tell my children the story of their grandfather. My father taught me through his actions. My father is my role model, my hero. My father, like his forefathers, made sacrifices so that our future would be brighter.

I thank you God, the Father Almighty, for my father. I miss him and I will keep him deep in my heart.

• Jim D. Pham is a parishioner at Our Lady of La Vang Parish (formerly St. Patrick Parish) in San Jose.

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By Chris Worldwide
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